From: [redacted]
To: Committee, EM (REPS)
Subject: JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE on ELECTORAL MATTERS
Date: Wednesday, 12 November 2025 2:40:16 PM

Good afternoon,

My name is Jeremy Graham.

I have been a member of the [redacted] (Southern Highlands NSW Branch) since March 2024. I have recently been given the opportunity to stand on the Executive, holding the Fund-Raising position.

Commencing in February this year, I was actively involved in the lead-up to this years Federal election, promoting [redacted]. I worked with other Branch members organising street stalls, meet-and-greets, banner-waving at busy traffic intersections and other associated activities to make [redacted]'s face known.
Like other Branch members, we were all a bit tired by the time the two-week pre-poll period commenced on Tuesday 22 April, but equally revved up for the big-push to election day on 03 May (and to see [redacted]!).

Pre-poll voting was taking place at the Senior Citizens Centre at Corbett Gardens in Bowral, which offers a reasonably large area for all Parties to have plenty of room to "sell our stuff" as it were.
From the get-go, it was obvious all Parties (including the [redacted], who had a large number of volunteers organised, working in 4hr shifts), that we were all vastly outnumbered by the volunteers for the [redacted].
The first week, they easily had 30 people volunteering to every other Parties three or four each day.

Things started easily enough, though a number of us from all the other Parties started questioning who the [redacted] volunteers were. None were recognised as being local. Many of them were also in the 20-40 years of age bracket, which seemed odd as they were all volunteering amongst the majority of others who are of retirement age (especially during the Monday-Friday periods).

As is the usual case, most of the Parties volunteers exchanged pleasant, harmless repartee. We were all respectful of each other and left alone to "do our job" while voters came and went.
All except the [redacted] volunteers.
They seemed to enjoy "crowding" the other volunteers as time went on which, needless to say, raised eyebrows. They also managed to arrive at the polling booth much earlier each day than any of the rest of us had been expecting, around 5.30am, garnering the best available positions.
A marquee were erected, directly opposite the entrance to the hall where voting was taking place. As voters were (at busy times) patiently queuing for entry, one particular [redacted] volunteer stood at the edge of the marquee verbally harassing these voters. It was not welcomed by the voters. The volunteer acted similarly to an auctioneer selling property.
Four-metre long banners were attached to the fences bordering Corbett Gardens. Their overall manner, at each peak entry point to the venue, was that of old-fashioned Circus spruikers or used-car salesmen, speaking at such volume as to potentially drown out what the other Parties volunteers were discussing with potential voters. They frequently would stand in front of voters, blocking their path.

They had many changes in shifts, all with even newer faces appearing.
Those of us who were game enough decide to seek information as to who these people were – such as enquiring as to where in the electorate they resided. Some of their answers were quite comical, which raised suspicions further. It became obvious over time that none of these people lived locally. When asked if they worked in the area, they all said that they did. All of them stated they were employed in family-owned businesses, which allowed them to take "annual leave" for the pre-poll period.

Several of us tried to just use humour to try and deflect what was becoming an uncomfortable venture as we stood at the correct distances from pathways etc as these other volunteers literally ran roughshod – ignoring the rules as set out by the Electoral Commission. They were bare-faced in their intentions. They were frequently told not to stand within the six-meter exclusion zone at the polling booth.
Several times complaints were made to the AEC booth manager by our co-ordinator on our behalf, and the AEC representative tried to control these volunteers behaviour. Inevitably, once reprimanded, they would then return to their previous behaviours, clearly unconcerned with any person of authority asking them to respect the rules as such. Local Council was kept informed of what was going on, but seemed powerless to take any action to kerb what was happening. Because the venue was Corbett Gardens, it was only Park Rangers who would visit, and that depended largely on what other activities they also had to attend each day. Frequent phone calls were made both to our organisers who then contacted the AEC. We volunteers felt ignored and helpless, expecting the AEC to have given back-up where there was none.

There were many times we were offered lollies, food, refreshments, even rain poncho's offered to all us other volunteers. Only a few of the other volunteers accepted these "niceties" which were plentiful. We were all equally non-plussed by such goings-on as none of us had ever witnessed such things at polling booths before these incidents occurred. They tried to use humour by telling us in a very patronising way that we were "taking the whole thing far too seriously" and to "lighten up". Those sort of comments only made the other volunteers angry and frustrated.

By the time Polling day had arrived, it became clear to all that these "volunteers" were members of the Plymouth Brethren. How that was uncovered, I don't know, but word spread quickly. Their volunteers were not embarrassed in the slightest that they had been "uncovered". They continued with even more zeal than previously displayed.

Most of the volunteers representing the other Parties were, by now, feeling resentful of what the [redacted] Party appeared to be doing. They had reduced a fair and democratic process to the equivalent of a race of "first past the post". Having seen the tactics employed by the [redacted] Party volunteers, some other Party's volunteers decided to do the same, frequently entering the exclusion zone.
The various Party volunteer organisers were justifiably frustrated and annoyed that the Electoral Commission had little to no control over these "volunteers" behaviour.

On Friday 02 May, the [redacted] candidate, [redacted], and [redacted] – [redacted], openly flouted regulations, standing within the six-metre exclusion zone at the entrance to the venue. They were both reminded of the rules and to stand outside the restricted area on at least six occasions. They both thought this was highly amusing.

In the end, the volunteers of ALL the other parties felt as though the [redacted] Party volunteers, due to the inaction of the AEC, given free-for-all to do as they wished, while the rest of us were mindful of the rules as set out by the AEC.
As a volunteer, I felt my duty (and time given) had been almost a waste of time. While I will still volunteer in the future I, like many other volunteers, will be thinking twice about what we may encounter as it felt as though the [redacted] Party were given free rein to do as they pleased.

Yours Sincerely
Jeremy Morrice Graham